

## Chapter 2

### Instructor's Manual

#### This chapter covers:

- The increasing differentiation among the varieties of English
- The presence or absence of /r/ in varieties of American English, specifically Labov's study of /r/ deletion in Manhattan, as well as a survey of more recent studies observing this variable
- Anthropological approaches to linguistic variation and Silverstein's (2003) notion of indexical order
- The sound changes involved in the Northern Cities Chain Shift
- Lexical variation in dialects and the discourse functions of the word *like*
- Variation in strong and weak verb morphology
- How speakers use linguistic variation to position themselves and others in the world

#### Sample answers to the questions from the text and the website

##### From the textbook

1. Consider the Salvucci map online:

<http://www.evolpub.com/Americandialects/AmDialMap.html> and read the descriptions he provided for each dialect area. How do they compare with your own understanding of the regional varieties of American English?

**Sample Answer:** This map and accompanying descriptions match many of my previously held ideas about American dialects. For example, I associate /r/-dropping with New York City and I recognize that most people on the west coast pronounce the words *cot* and *caught* the same. However, I was not aware of the differentiations between the Mountain Southern and Coastal Southern dialects or the distinction between the Upper Midwestern and Great Lakes dialects.

2. Think you have a pretty good handle on American dialects? Try the synonym quizzes on the website of the Dictionary of American Regional English. <http://dare.wisc.edu/?q=node/20>.

**Sample Answer:** I realize after doing this quiz that I am very unfamiliar with the vocabulary of many American English dialects! I didn't recognize most of the words on the list, but for the pairs I did get right, both terms for the item are a part of my vocabulary. It's amazing that there is such variation among American dialects that I could travel to parts of the country and potentially have a minor communication breakdown based on lexical differences such as these.

3. At the Harvard American Dialect Survey you will find the list of points of variation in American English that was included in that study. This is by no means a complete list of changes in progress, but there's quite a lot there. Before looking at the website and maps, identify three

*points of variation that you were aware of (in your own speech, or the speech of others you know) and three that you were not aware of.*

**Sample Answer:** Before looking at the maps and information on the Harvard American Dialect Survey website, I was aware of several points of variation in the United States. For example, I know that some people pronounce the words *cot* and *caught* the same way while others pronounce them differently, many people in the South pronounce the diphthong [ai] as a monophthong (for example, many Southerners would pronounce the word *rice* as *rahs*), and people in Northern California say the word *hella* (as in *It's hella cold outside*) while people in Southern California do not. After looking at the Harvard American Dialect Survey website, I also learned that there are dialect differences in how people pronounce the last vowel in words like *Monday* and *Friday*, that some American dialects can use more than one modal in a construction (as in *I might could do that*), and that there are 11 different terms for the bug I call a roly poly.

4. Look at the Dialect Map of /tɔk/ "talk" from the University of Texas linguistics department. <http://www.utexas.edu/courses/linguistics/resources/socioling/talkmap/index.html> -- and listen to the sound clips. Can you identify the vowels used in each geographic area? Can you hear the differences?

**Sample Answer:** I was able to distinctly hear the differences between the vowels used in each example and identify them with the help of the guide provided by the website. I find it very interesting that there are so many variations of the pronunciation of the same vowel and that none of them sound like the way I pronounce the word *talk*. This makes me wonder how many variations on the pronunciation of the word *talk* there are in the country.

5. A university or college campus often draws people from all over the country. Drawing on the diversity available to you for sampling, design a simple field study in which you look for the vowels in *cot* and *caught*, and map what you find. Where are the vowels distinct? Where are they merged? You might want to use Labov's (r) study as a model.

**Sample Answer:** For my study, I recruited students in the English Department at West Coast University to read a word list which included the following words: *cot*, *caught*, *taught*, *pot*, *bought*, *spot*, *hawk*, *mock*, *sock*, *don*, *dawn*, and *con*. This list was developed to try and elicit the contrasting vowels [a] and [ɔ]. I listened to each participant reciting these words and circled which vowel they used. I also asked them where they were raised in order to determine the geographical areas where these vowels are used. I recruited 34 participants. Of these 34 college students, 27 used only the [a] vowel in these words. For these 27 participants, *mock* and *sock* rhymed with *hawk*, *don* and *con* rhymed with *dawn*, and *cot* and *pot* rhymed with *caught*, *taught*, and *bought*. These 27 students were from California, Oregon, Washington, and Nevada. The remaining 7 students differentiated between the [a] and [ɔ] vowels. These 7 students were from Michigan, New York, and Delaware. From this data, I conclude that the differentiation of [a] and [ɔ] is a feature found more often in the eastern states, whereas lack of differentiation between these two vowels is a feature of the western states.

6. Attached to the Wikipedia page for the Northern Cities vowel/chain shift is a “talk” page where people can comment or make suggestions about the article. A series of comments from late 2010 includes the following reaction to the idea of the shift itself. How does this illustrate the concepts introduced thus far on standard language ideology?

*I'm Ohio born and raised and I've never come across this, I think this whole thing is BS. The people on TV still sound exactly like us, I can't think of any person I've ever met who has started or had changed into the first shift, more prevalent is rural people saying warsh. Are there any examples or a video of people with this “shift”? ... I know for a fact that I don't have a discernible accent and neither do most people I know.*

**Sample Answer:** This comment reveals much about standard language ideology. The author of this comment positions the “people on TV” as language authorities, and his or her belief that “the people on TV still sound just like us” is used as evidence that the Ohio variety of English is not changing. The commenter also reveals doubt about the changeability of language. In addition, the author’s reference to the language features of rural people connects to standard language ideology that tends to privilege the language of the urban elite over the language used in many rural communities. The author also assumes that he or she does not have an accent and neither do fellow members of his or her community. This statement reveals two parts of standard language ideology. First, it connects to the myth of the non-accent (see Chapter 3), and it also suggests that the varieties of English spoken in Ohio (often considered part of a general American dialect), are accent-free because they align with an idealized standard spoken language.

7. Consider the usage of *usta* (as in the sentence I usta go out on Saturday nights, but now I'm broke). Is it a verb, and if so, is it past or present tense? The answer is more complex and interesting than you might imagine, and you can read about it on Language Log, with this entry by Mark Liberman: <http://languageblog.ldc.upenn.edu/nll/?p=2756>.

**Sample answer:** Before looking at the Language Log post on this topic, my instinct was to think that *usta* was a past tense verb to express habitual actions or states. However, after reading the Language Log post I realize that my first instinctive analysis was too simple. I agree with Mark Liberman that *usta* is the result of analyzing “used to be” as “[used to] be” and is a fairly new aspectual verb with a very restricted distribution.

*From the Website*

## **Audio**

1. Listen to the samples of the dialects spoken in New York City, Boston, and New Hampshire found in the International Dialects of English Archive and The Speech Accent Archive. Pay careful attention to the speakers’ use or deletion of /r/. Compare the speakers’ use of /r/ to your own. How do these speakers sound similar to your own dialect and how do they sound different?

**Sample Answer:** In general, the female speakers from New Hampshire (New Hampshire 1, 2, and 4) sound the most like me in terms of /r/ usage. I am from the West Coast and my speech is very /r/-full, and the female New Hampshire speakers retained /r/ quite a bit. Listening to the

female New Hampshire speakers initially led me to believe that the New Hampshire dialect was rather /r/-full; however, when I listened to New Hampshire 3, I realized that there is a broad range of /r/-fullness in that area. New Hampshire 3, New York 9, and Massachusetts 6 are examples of speakers that sound the least like me due to their frequent /r/ deletion.

*2. Listen to a few of the samples of the dialects spoken in northern states and southern states found in the International Dialects of English Archive. Pay careful attention to the speakers' use or deletion of /r/. The chapter discusses a study by Feagin (1990) that concluded that, contrary to northern stereotypes of southern English being /r/-less, southern varieties of English were retaining more and more instances of /r/. In the samples you chose to listen to, did you notice a regional difference between the North and the South in the use or deletion of /r/?*

**Sample Answer:** I listened to five selections from the North and five from the South. I found a mix of /r/ usage and deletion in both regions. For example, South Carolina had faint /r/ usage in some contexts, and Mississippi 1 deleted /r/ at times, but Louisiana 2, Arkansas 3, and Tennessee 8 retained /r/ in these contexts. In the North, Wisconsin 3, Michigan 10, and North Dakota 1 all were very /r/-full, but New Hampshire 3 and Massachusetts 6 typically deleted postvocalic /r/. Based on this limited data, there seems to be variation within both the North and the South in regards to /r/ use, and it does appear that at least some Southern speakers are using postvocalic /r/.

*3. Listen to the samples of the dialects spoken in Illinois, New York, Michigan, and Ohio found in the International Dialects of English Archive. Pay careful attention to the speakers' vowels. Compare the speakers' vowels to your own. How do these speakers sound similar to the way you speak? How do they sound different? Pay special attention to the vowels affected by the Northern Cities Chain Shift.*

**Sample Answer:** I found several examples of the Northern Cities Chain Shift in the samples from these states. For example, in Illinois 3 and Ohio 2, there are good examples of the vowel that is pronounced as [æ] in much of the country being pronounced as [ɪə] (in words such as *at* and *happy*). In addition, in Michigan 1 and New York 1, the speakers pronounce the vowel in the word *pot* and the first vowel in *father* as a fronted [a] that sounds very close to [æ]. Most of these speakers' vowels sound pretty similar to mine, but since I do not live in an area experiencing the Northern Cities Chain Shift, my pronunciations of [æ] and [a] are quite different from those found in the samples I listened to from Illinois, New York, Michigan, and Ohio.

*4. Listen to the samples of the dialects spoken in Chicago found in the International Dialects of English Archive. Is this an accent that you can identify as being from Chicago? If so, what cues indicate a Chicago accent for you? If not, where would you have guessed these speakers were from and why?*

**Sample Answer:** I thought I could have identified these samples as being from Chicago based on the features that I now know are part of the Northern Cities Chain Shift. The pronunciation of [a] as [æ] and the pronunciation of [æ] as [ɪə] were features that I thought indicated a speaker as being from Chicago; however, now I know that these features are not restricted to Chicago but also affect other cities in Midwestern states.

## Video

“Snooks Cooks”

*Jersey Shore*

Season 2, Episode 23, Deleted Scene

<http://www.mtv.com/videos/misc/628301/snooks-cooks.jhtml#id=1659128>

“Legit Depressed”

*Jersey Shore*

Season 2, Episode 26, Deleted Scene

<http://www.mtv.com/videos/misc/635386/legit-depressed.jhtml#id=1660548>

Discussion questions:

1. Pay attention to whether or not the cast members use postvocalic /r/ in their speech. When do Deena, Vinny, Snooki, and Pauly D use postvocalic /r/? When does the /r/ get deleted? Which cast members use /r/ the most? Which use it the least? If you watch the show and are familiar with their personalities, can you make any comment on how each person’s language use reflects his or her identity?

**Sample Answer:** I didn’t find a clear example of Deena deleting /r/, but there are examples of the other three cast members deleting postvocalic /r/. For example, Snooki deletes postvocalic /r/ in the word *there* (and *there’s*) and *for* but retains the second /r/ in the word *prefer*. Pauly deletes the /r/ in the words *your* and *clear*, and Vinny deletes /r/ in the word *her* many times in the second clip. It’s hard to say who deletes postvocalic /r/ the most of these cast members based on only two clips. Vinny’s /r/ deletion was the most noticeable to me, but that could be because he uses the word *her* many times in the clip. Pauly deleted the word /r/ or softened it up quite a bit in the widest number of words since his pronunciation of the words *turn* and *girls* also had a nearly-deleted /r/.

I don’t watch the show regularly, so I can’t be confident in my answer, but I would hypothesize that the cast members who affiliate most strongly with an identity as a member of an /r/-dropping community will drop postvocalic /r/ most often.

2. How do the cast members featured in these clips use the word *like* as a discourse marker? Can you find examples of *like* used as a quotative or a focuser?

**Sample Answer:** There are examples of the word *like* being used as a quotative and a focuser in these clips. For example, in the first clip, both Snooki and Pauly use *like* as a quotative. Snooki says, “So I was **like**, ‘Why don’t we have some hot dogs?’” and Pauly says, “Snooki told me the same thing, she’s **like** ‘Whoever I’m marrying I’m not gonna cook for.’” In these examples, both cast members use *like* to signal that they are quoting another person in their narrative. Deena uses *like* as a focuser twice when she says, “I felt like I had **like** a really strong relationship with Vinny” and “I’m **like** legit depressed.” These uses of *like* focus the listener on the relationship with Vinny and the sadness she is feeling as the result of the conflict.

### **Suggested activities and discussion questions**

1. Discuss the notion of prestige, especially as it relates to Labov's study of /r/ use in Manhattan. Ask the students to compare and contrast the way they speak in different social situations or different communities. Can they confidently label one variety as the most prestigious or does prestige vary by community and situation for them? What does the amount of prestige assigned to a language variety tell them about the values and ideologies connected to language?
2. Find out how many of your students use the word *like* as a discourse marker. Next, encourage students to brainstorm what stereotypes surround this use of *like*. Who is the stereotypical user of *like* as a discourse marker? What attributes does this stereotypical speaker have? Do they think these stereotypes have changed over the years? What do these stereotypes reveal about language ideology and attitudes toward the portion of the population that uses this discourse marker?
3. Ask the students if they are aware of any verb conjugations that they (or others) consider "incorrect" (for example, *snuck*, *dove*, *drug*, choices between *lay* and *lie*, etc.). What do these "incorrect" verb conjugations reveal about language change? What does the sometimes fierce resistance to these changes reveal about standard language ideology?
4. To enhance discussion of this chapter, please visit the companion website and check out the audio and video clips available for use in your classroom.